

The Executive Guide to Financial Crime Defense With Data and AI

A concise briefing for financial services executives, spanning retail, corporate, and institutional banking, on the state of fraud and anti-money laundering (AML), what regulators are demanding globally, and how the Data and AI Platform helps banks get ahead. Fraud and Anti-Financial Crime (AFC) — AML, sanctions, KYC — are usually owned by different teams with different mandates; this guide covers the requirements facing both, wherever your program sits.



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SECTION 1

The Current Landscape

A system under strain

Financial institutions are fighting financial crime, fraud and money laundering at a scale and speed the last-generation infrastructure was never built to handle. Across retail digital channels, cross-border corporate payment corridors and complex trade finance networks, the explosion of real-time transactions and generative AI has vastly widened the attack surface. Defenses built for static, siloed data are buckling under the weight of sophisticated multilayered shell companies, synthetic identities and hyper-automated scams. Boards have taken notice: Financial crime prevention now shows up as a core strategic risk on the executive agenda, not an operational line item buried in the back office.

Three pressures are compounding at once.

- 1 Compliance is getting more expensive to run** — The \$61B in annual U.S. and Canada financial-crime compliance cost cited below reflects manual, headcount-heavy operations that don't scale with transaction volume⁵
- 2 Regulatory expectations are shifting from point-in-time checks to continuous obligations** — What used to be a periodic Know Your Customer (KYC) refresh increasingly means real-time, evidence-ready due diligence, and even where regimes simplify on paper, as the EU's proposed Digital Omnibus aims to do, the underlying bar for demonstrable governance keeps rising rather than falling²⁴
- 3 The adversary itself has changed** — Guidance from the Financial Action Task Force (FATF) describes coordinated, cross-border fraud rings probing for the gaps between institutions and jurisdictions, increasingly aided by generative AI¹²

The numbers make the case on their own:

90% of FATF-assessed jurisdictions now name fraud a major money-laundering risk ¹	\$442B lost to scams globally across 42 countries in the past year, per the Global Anti-Scam Alliance's 2025 State of Scams report ²
~2% of global illicit financial flows are actually detected, per McKinsey ³	90–95% of AML transaction-monitoring alerts are false positives ⁴
\$61B annual financial-crime compliance cost across the U.S. and Canada ⁵	417% jump in global financial-crime penalties in H1 2025 ⁶

With mandatory reimbursement regimes now active in major markets, including the UK's Payment Systems Regulator rules and the EU's Instant Payments framework, banks are increasingly required to absorb authorized push payment scam losses onto their own balance sheets rather than passing that liability to the customer. This shifts fraud prevention from a customer protection issue to a direct P&L (profit and loss) exposure.⁷

Criminals are getting smarter and more professional faster than defenses are modernizing. FATF's 2026 cyber-enabled fraud paper describes fraud rings operating as coordinated, cross-border networks, testing bank controls repeatedly until they find the gap between institutions, channels and jurisdictions. Deepfake-enabled identity fraud has grown more than twentyfold in just a few years. KYC and onboarding controls built for a world of static documents were never designed to catch it, and the same fraud rings that beat onboarding controls often feed the laundering pipeline downstream.

THE STAKES

"The financial industry detects only about 2% of global financial crime flows, despite increasing spending by up to 10% a year in some advanced markets."

McKinsey & Company⁸

Is a unified fraud and AML platform actually buildable?

Before the regulatory case and the architecture, there are two practical questions executives ask first about consolidating fraud, AML and regulatory reporting onto one governed platform: Has this actually been built before, and does it require starting over? Both answers are concrete: yes and no.

This isn't rip and replace. Most institutions keep the front-end tools and specific vendor components that already work — biometrics, sanctions-list screeners, case management user interfaces — while unifying the underlying data and orchestration layer. What changes is who owns the data, the models and the audit trail, not which vendor logo sits on every screen. (More on this trade-off in Section 6.)

It doesn't start as a multiyear platform migration. **Databricks' Solution Accelerators**, pre-built notebooks and reference architectures for anti-money laundering (AML) and fraud, are designed to take a team from idea to a working proof of concept in as little as two weeks, using real (not synthetic) data from day one.⁹

Accelerators are the on-ramp, not the destination: Institutions increasingly want a single, integrated application layer for fraud, AML and case management running on the Databricks Platform, not notebooks they have to assemble themselves. Genie One is the data-smart AI coworker at the center of that layer — the natural-language interface investigators and compliance teams actually sit in front of, not a data science tool.

Databricks is already running at scale, not just in pilots. **Nine of 10 global systemically important banks (G-SIBs) and 2,000+ financial services institutions run production workloads on the Databricks Platform today.** That's the base rate this proposal is built on — it's not a bet on unproven technology.¹⁰

Governed AI in a bank is a solved problem, independent of AML specifically. **Coastal Community Bank** runs a 91% adoption rate of **Unity Catalog** across their model lifecycle, access controls, lineage tracking and monitoring, verified against the Databricks AI Security Framework. It's a security and governance story rather than an AML one, but it's real, it's named and it answers the question of whether a regulated bank can actually operationalize this kind of governance, not just diagram it.¹¹

SECTION 2

Regulatory and Industry Pressure

What regulators and industry bodies are demanding

The direction of travel from FATF, national regulators and industry associations is consistent, and it points squarely at data and technology modernization across both fraud and AML and across every jurisdiction a bank touches.

Fraud is now a laundering predicate, not a side issue. FATF's cyber-enabled fraud guidance links scam proceeds directly to downstream laundering. Banks are being pushed to unify fraud and AML detection instead of running them as separate programs on separate data.¹²

Explainability matters as much as accuracy. FATF's AI "horizon scan" and national supervisors increasingly expect institutions to show why a model flagged or cleared an alert. This means a hybrid of rules and machine learning with a full audit trail behind every decision.

Data infrastructure is now a supervisory expectation, not an internal IT project. FATF's guidance on digital transformation names data pooling, collaborative analytics and reduced false positives as the practical payoff of modernization, and calls out legacy systems and poor data quality as the two barriers industry hits most often.

Cross-border friction is hitting a regulatory ceiling. As the G20 pushes for faster, cheaper global payments, FATF's updated Recommendation 16 (the "Travel Rule") requires institutions to transmit standardized identity data and use active recipient-verification technology on cross-border transfers over \$1,000. Cross-border compliance costs are scaling faster than most institutions can absorb manually, and regulators expect banks to replace legacy architecture with systems that instantly handle sanctions and fraud screening directly in the transaction path.¹³

AI itself now falls under governance requirements. Guidance for 2026 from FATF and national bodies tightens expectations on AI governance, model risk management and human-in-the-loop controls. Lineage, access control and auditability have moved from best practice to compliance requirement.

The EU AI Act formalizes these AI governance requirements for high-risk financial services use cases, though the European Commission's proposed Digital Omnibus signals that the compliance mechanics are still being negotiated and aren't yet the underlying expectation.²⁴ Supervisors outside Europe are converging on the same standard through different instruments — from the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) AI Risk Management Framework to the State of New York's Department of Financial Services (DFS) Part 504 certification requirement for transaction-monitoring systems — so the audit-trail bar is becoming a global one, not just a regional one.²⁵

Europe is consolidating enforcement under a single authority. EU enforcement is shifting from fragmented national guidelines to a single binding authority. The newly established EU Anti-Money Laundering Authority (AMLA) is finalizing a unified rule book ahead of July 2027 enforcement. Cross-border institutions will need to deliver automated Ultimate Beneficial Ownership (UBO) verification and machine-readable audit trails directly to AMLA's supervisory teams. Noncompliance carries real consequences: Systemic data failures risk penalties of up to €10 million or 10% of total annual turnover.¹⁴

BOTTOM LINE

Regulators have stopped asking whether banks should modernize fraud and AML infrastructure with AI. The question now is whether banks can prove that modernization is governed, explainable and auditable across every jurisdiction and every division.

SECTION 3

The Gap

Why legacy fraud and AML stacks are breaking down

Most institutions run fraud prevention, AML compliance and regulatory reporting on a fragmented patchwork: a rules-based transaction monitoring system here, a standalone corporate case management tool there, a data warehouse that only refreshes overnight and siloed KYC and UBO vendors bolted on top. Each piece works fine in isolation. Together, they create the exact blind spots global regulators are calling out across retail, corporate and institutional divisions alike.

Headcount is the number one hidden cost. Opaque, static thresholds generate the 90–95% false-positive rates cited in Section 1, and every false positive still needs a person to clear it. That means large, primarily manual investigations teams whose headcount doesn't scale with transaction volume and a workload that drives analyst burnout and turnover. Every experienced analyst who leaves takes institutional knowledge of the bank's own typologies with them, which is its own control gap.

➔ Siloed data, fragmented risk view

High-value corporate transactions, unstructured trade finance files (like bills of lading), legal entity identifiers and device telemetry sit in disconnected environments. No single system provides a unified view of a customer, let alone the hidden graph networks connecting shell companies across offshore jurisdictions.

➔ Batch, not real-time

Many fraud engines still score overnight or on a delay, and core AML platforms run overnight scoring too. Batch processing and overnight cycles create blind spots in the real-time, cross-border payment corridors the G20 is actively targeting for modernization. This leaves a window during which fast-moving fraud and mule-network activity goes undetected until the next business day, sometimes long after the money has moved.

➔ Alert fatigue by design

Opaque, static thresholds generate the 90–95% false-positive rates cited in Section 1. Investigation teams are buried under administrative noise, driving up headcount costs while stretching the time-to-detection for sophisticated, multilayered institutional laundering typologies.

➔ Proprietary black boxes

Licensed fraud and AML engines are often opaque even to the bank's own data science teams. Retraining a model on institution-specific typologies or explaining a decision to an examiner becomes a negotiation with the vendor rather than something the bank can just do.

➔ Fragmented cost and lock-in

Separate licenses for fraud, AML, KYC and regulatory reporting each carry their own infrastructure, integration and vendor management overhead. There's no shared data layer to spread that cost across and no easy way to catch a fraud pattern that's also an early signal of laundering.

Globally, the threat landscape and the regulatory bar have both moved, and the infrastructure for most institutions hasn't kept pace with either.

SECTION 4

The Databricks Approach

One governed platform for fraud, AML and regulatory reporting

The Databricks Platform enables retail, corporate and institutional banks to unify transaction data, KYC records, device and behavioral signals, unstructured case files and external intelligence, then layer real-time detection, governed AI and agentic investigation on top of it.

➔ Open architecture, no lock-in

Banks run on any major cloud and can bring their own models rather than working inside a vendor's proprietary detection logic. Under DORA's cloud-concentration-risk requirements, banks now have to document and assess their reliance on any single cloud provider. Architecture that keeps that door open isn't a preference anymore. It's part of the compliance case.¹⁵

In practice, institutions rarely build this open architecture alone. The same architecture typically runs entity-resolution and case-management ISVs like Quantexa, gets deployed by global systems integrators and gets built out by consulting partners such as Deloitte for governance and migration work.

➔ One data layer, built in, not bolted on

Section 3 named the core problem: retail transactions, wholesale corporate wires, unstructured trade files and legal entity data scattered across systems, with no single view of risk. Delta Lake and Unity Catalog bring structured, unstructured and third-party data into one unified, governed layer with fine-grained access control and full lineage. Fraud models, AML models and automated investigation agents all draw on this same underlying data instead of a synced copy running a day late. It's the exact operational posture FATF recommends: a single, holistic view that unifies fraud and AML detection across both retail and corporate divisions.

➔ Advanced entity resolution at scale

The Databricks Platform lets institutions ingest messy, disconnected data from core banking systems, SWIFT logs and external corporate registries (OpenCorporates, Dun & Bradstreet and similar). Running entity resolution directly on the data layer resolves duplicate profiles, matches disparate records and surfaces the true UBO across complex corporate structures in real time.

➔ Native graph analytics for network disruption

Financial crime rarely happens in isolation. It operates in networks. Instead of analyzing transactions one at a time, the Databricks Platform uses high-performance graph processing to map relationships across millions of accounts, entities and jurisdictions. Corporate banking teams can untangle nested shell companies, expose hidden cyclic payment loops and spot money-mule rings that traditional relational databases miss entirely.

UNIFIED CROSS-BORDER RISK VIEW

BEFORE:

Data siloed by retail, commercial and geographical divisions, with high latencies masking multilayered illicit networks

AFTER:

One governance fabric spanning data and AI, running scalable entity resolution and native graph analytics to expose hidden corporate risk across global nodes

➔ Governance that grows with the data, instead of chasing it

FATF and national supervisors expect explainability and full audit trails as standard practice now (Section 2). Databricks AI governance runs on the same underlying architecture as the data governance most banks already use for compliance. Lineage, access control and audit trails apply to models the same way they already apply to data, whether the model is scoring a live transaction or triaging a case.

➔ Real-time fraud detection, without a second stack to maintain

Fraud detection has one unforgiving requirement: A fraudulent transaction has to be caught before it settles, not after. With the Databricks Platform, sub-300ms real-time scoring is integrated directly into the payment path itself to block fraud and high-risk capital movement before settlement occurs, using the same streaming engine already running its AML and case-management workloads. No separate specialized streaming engine, no second system for the risk team to integrate and maintain.¹⁶

➔ Cloud and multi-region flexibility

For institutions operating across borders, data residency isn't optional. The Databricks Platform keeps data in region to meet strict data-residency laws while still running federated compliance analytics across the group. This way, a global institution can satisfy local regulators without losing a unified view of risk.

➔ Agentic investigation, with the paperwork to prove it

Multi-agent systems, orchestrated through Genie and Agent Bricks triage alerts, pull evidence from structured and unstructured sources, and draft narratives for suspicious activity reports (SAR). Investigators spend their time on judgment calls instead of data wrangling. SAR filings, which traditionally take banks around 21 hours of manual effort per Bank Policy Institute survey data, compress to minutes when an agent fleet handles evidence gathering and drafting.¹⁷

WHY IT MATTERS

On the AML side, Databricks architecture has shown a 75% reduction in false positives and 8 to 10 times faster case processing, translating to an estimated \$50–\$150 million in annual savings for a medium-to-large institution.¹⁸

On the fraud side, the real-time architecture of the Databricks Platform catches a bad transaction in sub-300ms, before it settles, with no separate streaming engine required.¹⁹

SECTION 5

Proof in Production

Customer outcomes

Global tier-1 institutions, regional banks, corporate banks and digital asset platforms are running massive, high-volume financial crime and fraud workloads on the Databricks Platform. The production results back up the case for a unified, governed data and AI platform that scales effortlessly across retail channels, institutional wholesale payment rails and global market operations.

→ NATIONAL AUSTRALIA BANK (NAB)

NAB modernized 456 use cases off a 26-year-old legacy platform onto the Databricks Platform, using Unity Catalog, Lakeflow and serverless compute to balance rapid AI-driven innovation with enterprise-grade governance across risk, fraud and compliance domains. It's a model for how a large institution can scale AI without losing control of it.²⁰

→ BROKERAGE FIRM

A top global bank replaced a fragmented stack of legacy databases and manual desktop scripts with a governed regulatory reporting hub on the Databricks Platform — collapsing liquidity reporting from 10 hours to 8 minutes, a 75x improvement, while making the numbers fully auditable for the first time. It's the batch-to-real-time problem named in Section 3, solved at one of the pattern's highest-stakes use cases: regulatory reporting under Comprehensive Capital Analysis and Review (CCAR)-level scrutiny.²¹

→ RABOBANK

Rabobank uses Unity Catalog to move their credit analytics and compliance infrastructure onto a secure, audit-ready architecture with scope-based access controls and automated data governance — built with strategic partner Deloitte. It's a governance story, not an AML-specific one, but it's the same underlying control plane the fraud and AML architecture described in this guide depends on, running today at one of Europe's largest cooperative banks.²⁴

→ ERSTE GROUP BANK AG

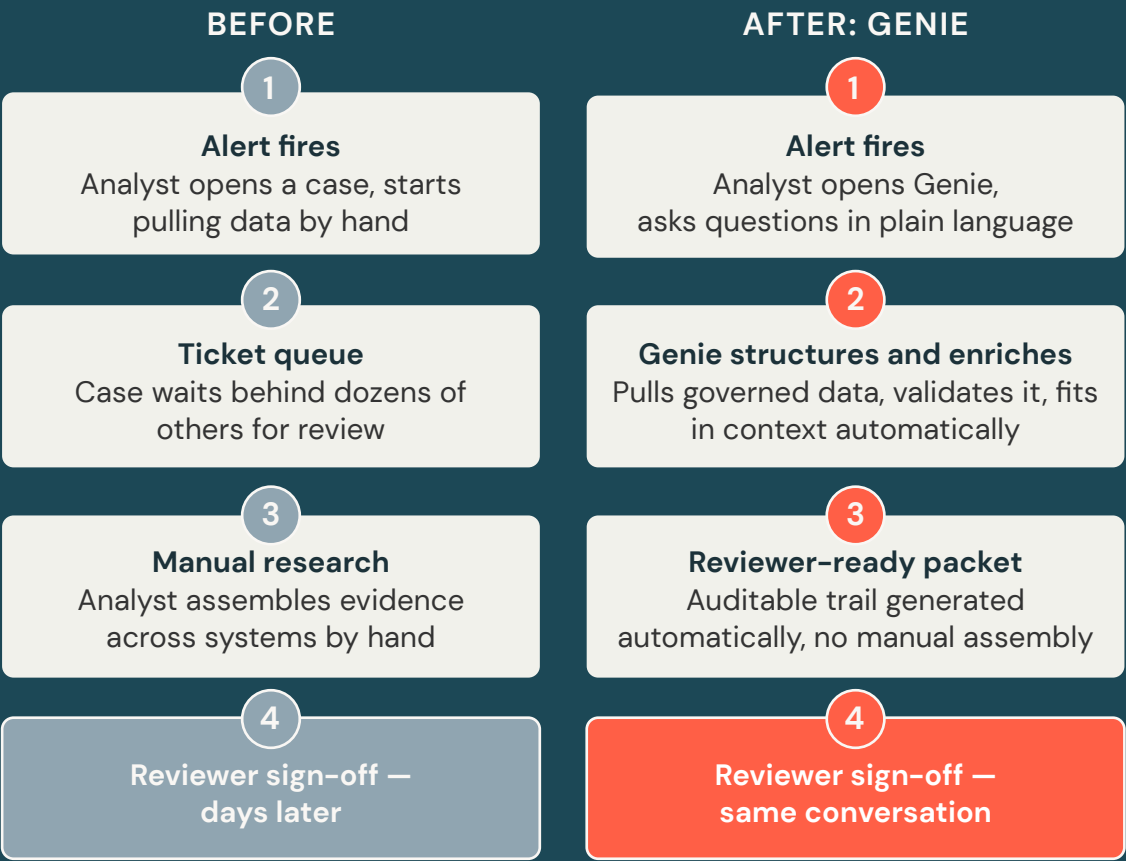
One of the largest retail banks in Central and Eastern Europe replaced ticket-based compliance workflows with a Genie-powered conversational assistant built on Agent Bricks. Users just talk. The system structures, validates and enriches the input, then produces reviewer-ready packets covering EU AI Act obligations, security and architecture — with an auditable trail throughout. It's the "Headcount is the #1 hidden cost" problem from Section 3, solved with the exact agentic pattern this guide describes.²⁴

→ TOP-10 U.S. BANK (Partner Case Study)

A top-10 U.S. bank replaced a legacy, rules-based fraud engine with real-time machine learning on the Databricks Platform, scoring more than 50 million transactions a day in under 100 milliseconds. It's a direct example of moving beyond static fraud rules to AI-driven detection at payment scale, reducing false positives by 71% while avoiding an estimated \$28 million in annual fraud losses.

Modernizing fraud investigations with AI

Avanade demonstrates how Genie enables fraud investigators to query governed enterprise data using natural language, reducing time spent searching across systems so teams can focus on detecting and investigating financial crime.



Business outcomes

Sub-300ms	end-to-end transaction scoring latency on Databricks real-time fraud detection architecture
8-10x	faster case processing on Databricks BSA/AML architecture
75%	reduction in false positives from the same AML architecture
\$50-150M	estimated annual savings for a medium-to-large institution running the BSA/AML architecture
10 hrs → 8 min	regulatory process time achieved
456	use cases migrated from legacy infrastructure to the Databricks Platform

SECTION 6

The Alternative

The Databricks Platform vs. the traditional vendor stack

Proprietary fraud and AML suites are fundamentally built for single-jurisdiction, static banking environments. What global regulators from AMLA in Europe to the Financial Crimes Enforcement Network (FinCEN) in the U.S. care about now is whether a cross-border institution can demonstrate unified data governance, immutable data lineage and model explainability on demand across every operating footprint. Relying on a black box designed for the last generation of localized crime typologies is not good enough.

This comparison is not an argument for a forced rip and replace of every legacy core system a global bank runs. Most cross-border institutions operate a hybrid architecture, keeping localized front-end tools or specific sanctions-list screeners while unifying the underlying data intelligence and orchestration layer underneath. What fundamentally changes with the Databricks Platform is who controls the infrastructure, the cross-border audit trail and the intelligence engine, whether a transaction is clearing in London, New York or Singapore.

	TRADITIONAL VENDOR STACK	DATABRICKS PLATFORM
Data ownership	Data held in proprietary formats within the vendor’s system	Open lakehouse, bank owns the data, models and audit trail
Model transparency	Detection logic is vendor IP, difficult to retrain or explain to an examiner	Bank trains models on their own data, using their own typologies
Cloud and multiregional flexibility	Often tied to a specific infrastructure commitment, a poor fit for data residency requirements	Keeps data in region to hit strict data residency laws while running federated compliance analytics
Governance	Data governance and AI governance frequently built by separate teams	Same architecture spans data and AI governance
Speed to insight	Batch processing and overnight cycles create blind spots in real-time, cross-border payment corridors (G20 targets)	Sub-300ms real-time scoring integrated directly into the payment path to block fraud and high-risk capital before settlement occurs
Proof at scale	Case studies typically narrow to a single product	9 of 10 G-SIBs and 2,000+ financial services institutions in production

- Gartner named Databricks a Leader in its Gartner® Magic Quadrant,™ AI Platforms for Data Science and Machine Learning with the Highest Ability to Execute and furthest Completeness of Vision, for the second consecutive year.²²
- Two further Gartner reports name Databricks specifically in a banking context.²³
- [Hype Cycle for Data and Analytics in Banking, 2025](#)
 - [Strategic Benefits and Technical Considerations of Databricks for Bank CIOs](#)

SECTION 7

Getting Started

A 90-day path

Institutions don't need a multi-year transformation program to see a return here. A focused first phase on one high-pain use case, whether that's real-time fraud scoring, cross-border entity resolution, mule network detection, or SAR narrative drafting, typically proves value within a quarter and builds the governed foundation everything else scales on.

PHASE	WHAT HAPPENS	OUTCOME
DAYS 1-30	Discover and assess: Map current fraud and AML data sources, false-positive rates, cross-border data residency requirements and one priority use case	Shared risk and readiness view
DAYS 30-60	Pilot on real, governed data: Stand up unified data layer, run real-time fraud scoring or agentic AML triage against live cases using Genie for analyst-facing alert triage	Measured false-positive, latency and speed gains
DAYS 60-90+	Scale and govern: Extend to fraud, AML, KYC, entity resolution and regulatory reporting across jurisdictions on the same platform with full lineage	Board- and examiner-ready program



Talk to us
Contact us today to get started.

LEARN MORE

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¹³ FATF, [update to Recommendation 16 on Payment Transparency](#), June 2025 Plenary.

¹⁴ [A&O Shearman, “AML/CTF Playbook: EU Edition #2: The EU Anti-Money Laundering Authority \(AMLA\) — The New Supervisory Framework,” July 16, 2026.](#)

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¹⁹ Databricks, “How to Build Real-Time Fraud Detection using Spark Real-Time Mode and Lakebase” (see note 16).

²⁰ Databricks customer story, National Australia Bank, “[Decommissioning a Heritage Data Warehouse for a Modern Lakehouse Future](#).”

²¹ Databricks, “[Beyond the Spreadsheet: How Databricks Is Delivering the Modern CFO in Financial Services](#),” 2026. The source itself attributes this figure to “a top global bank,” not a named institution.

²² Gartner® Magic Quadrant,™ AI Platforms for Data Science and Machine Learning.

²³ [Gartner®, Hype Cycle for Data and Analytics in Banking, 2025.](#)
[Gartner®, Strategic Benefits and Technical Considerations of Databricks for Bank CIOs.](#)

²⁴ Databricks, “[Adaptive Data Governance for EU Regulatory Change](#),” February 25, 2026, — names Rabobank, Raiffeisen, Erste Group, Santander Bank Polska, and ABN AMRO; Deloitte cited as strategic partner.

²⁵ [NIST AI Risk Management Framework](#) (AI RMF 1.0), January 2023, and New York State Department of Financial Services, 23 NYCRR Part 504 (transaction monitoring and filtering program certification).

About Databricks

Databricks is the data and AI company. More than 20,000 organizations worldwide — including adidas, AT&T, Bayer, Block, Mastercard, Rivian, Unilever and 70% of the Fortune 500 — rely on Databricks to build and scale data and AI apps, analytics and agents. Headquartered in San Francisco, with 30+ offices around the globe, Databricks offers a unified platform that includes Lakebase, Genie, Agent Bricks, Lakeflow, Lakehouse and Unity Catalog. To learn more, follow Databricks on [LinkedIn](#), [X](#), [YouTube](#) and [Facebook](#).

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